

**Unit 1, Option A,
Topic A5: Anglo-
French Rivalry:
Henry V and
Henry VI, 1413-53**

The focus of this topic is on the last great phase of the Hundred Years War during the reigns of Henry V and his son and the dramatic change in the fortunes of war from glorious victory at Agincourt to decisive defeat at Castillon in 1453. Since the focus of this unit is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the specification bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the specification bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of the specification offer a framework for understanding the themes of the exercise of royal military power under Henry V and the challenges to that power in the reign of Henry VI. Bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, the existence or non-existence of Burgundy as an ally played an important part in explaining success (bullet point 2 and 3) and failure (bullet point 4).

The first bullet point relates to why Henry V invaded France in 1415 and actively re-asserted his claim to the throne of France. Students should understand the complex interaction: of causation involving the personal characteristics and position of Henry; the favourable circumstances provided by the rivalry of the Burgundian and Armagnac factions in France; the inadequacies of Charles VI; and the passivity of Scotland.

The second bullet point relates to the period of successful conflict under Henry V. Students should have an understanding of: the capture of Harfleur in 1415; the reasons for the staggering victory at Agincourt later in the year; the diplomacy of 1416, bringing Henry into alliance with Burgundy and the Empire; the invasion and conquest of Normandy in 1417-19; and the triumphant Treaty of Troyes in 1420 and the occupation of Paris in that year.

The third bullet point relates to the first years of the reign of the infant Henry VI and the importance of John, Duke of Bedford and the Burgundian alliance in upholding the English position in France during the king's minority. Students should understand the importance of Joan of Arc in relieving Orleans and re-invigorating the Armagnac cause, but also the limits of her success, for example the failure to capture Paris and her own capture and death.